

Problem statement

The journey of a 'feature' in an ideal state encompasses multiple stages that are carefully designed to ensure its successful development and implementation. These stages guide the feature through its entire life cycle, from conceptualisation to deployment and beyond.

- **Scoping, discovery and framing:** Defines the purpose and objectives of the feature
- **Stakeholder mapping using RACI (responsible, accountable, consulted, informed) framework:** Identifying and assigning roles and responsibilities to various stakeholders
- **Graphing the stakeholder influence vs interest charts:** Prioritising stakeholders based on their level of influence and interest in the feature
- **Defining the customer problem, business problem and success metrics:** Defining success metrics helps in measuring the feature's impact and effectiveness
- **Defining personas, current behaviours, and future behaviours:** Understanding the target audience and their behaviours through personas
- **Creating customer journey, empathy and assumption mappings:** Creating a holistic view of user interactions and pain points
- **SWOT (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats) analysis for the product and team:** Identifying internal and external factors that can impact a feature's potential success
- **Prioritisation of features:** Ranking and selecting features based on their importance, feasibility and potential impact
- **Solutioning:** Design, development, test and deploy
- **Experimentation:** Observation, hypothesis, test and evidence: Data driven decision making through an experimentation process
- **Implementation:** Changing, adjusting and refining the feature based on the results of experimentation.

This comprehensive journey framework ensures that features are not only developed but also well-informed, tested, and continuously improved. It reflects a user-centric and data-driven approach to feature development, promoting success and satisfaction for both users and the business.

However, even after this rigorous requirement gathering process, it is common in the software development process that the deployed features do not yield the desired results for various reasons.

- **Changing user needs:** Changing user needs and market conditions, coupled with developmental delays, can render initially prioritised requirements obsolete.
- **Lack of end user involvement and inadequate user research:** The absence of end user involvement in the requirement gathering process can result in overlooking or

misunderstanding their actual needs and preferences.

- **Unclear business objectives:** It can be challenging to prioritise requirements effectively when business objectives are not well defined.
- **Incorrect assumptions:** Relying on unvalidated assumptions about customer preferences made by the stakeholders can result in inaccurate prioritisation, posing a potential risk.
- **Ineffective prioritisation criteria:** If the criterion for prioritisation is not well-defined, it can lead to inconsistent choices. Prioritisation decisions can sometimes be influenced by the preferences of powerful stakeholders, rather than aligning with user needs or the product's goals.
- **Miscommunication:** Unclear communication between stakeholders can lead to misinterpretations of what the users truly need.
- **Bias:** Personal biases or preconceived notions about the prioritisation may lead to incorrect choices.
- **Resource constraints:** Limited resources such as time, budget or skilled personnel can force teams to make trade-offs based on constraints rather than the value provided to the end user.

Delivering the wrong or ineffective features in a project can have far-reaching consequences that significantly affect the project's overall success and can lead to several problems and challenges.

- **User abandonment, customer dissatisfaction and low customer retention:** Upon encountering inadequate or irrelevant features, users may choose to abandon the product leading to diminished customer satisfaction and decrease in customer retention rate.
- **Cost overruns, delay in the project timelines and revenue downturn:** Inclusion of inadequate features can disrupt the project's budget, causing unexpected cost overrun and potential downturn in revenue generation.
- **Resource misallocation:** Incorrectly chosen features can lead to the misallocation of critical resources, thereby impeding the overall efficiency.
- **Security risks and legal consequences:** Inadequate features may inadvertently introduce security vulnerabilities which can lead to legal consequences.
- **Technical debt:** Poorly implemented or inappropriate features can contribute to technical debt, impacting long term sustainability.
- **Developer productivity impact:** Developers faced with the challenge of adapting to unsuitable features may experience a decline in productivity resulting in longer development cycles.
- **Market share erosion:** Suboptimal features can undermine the product's competitiveness leading to a gradual erosion of market share.